

GLOSSARY

Academic libertarian: someone (like myself) who considers that knowledge is subjected to strict rules but not institutional authority, as the interest of organized knowledge is self-perpetuation, not necessarily truth (as with governments). Academia can suffer from an acute **expert problem** (q.v.), producing cosmetic but fake knowledge, particularly in **narrative disciplines** (q.v.), and can be a main source of Black Swans.

Apelles-style strategy: A strategy of seeking gains by collecting positive accidents from maximizing exposure to “good Black Swans.”

Barbell strategy: a method that consists of taking both a defensive attitude and an excessively aggressive one at the same time, by protecting assets from all sources of uncertainty while allocating a small portion for high-risk strategies.

Bildungsphilister: a philistine with cosmetic, nongenuine culture. Nietzsche used this term to refer to the dogma-prone newspaper reader and opera lover with cosmetic exposure to culture and shallow depth. I extend it to the buzzword-using researcher in nonexperimental fields who lacks in imagination, curiosity, erudition, and culture and is closely centered on his ideas, on his “discipline.” This prevents him from seeing the conflicts between his ideas and the texture of the world.

Black Swan blindness: the underestimation of the role of the Black Swan, and occasional overestimation of a specific one.

Black Swan ethical problem: Owing to the nonrepeatable aspect of the Black Swan, there is an asymmetry between the rewards of those who prevent and those who cure.

Confirmation error (or Platonic confirmation): You look for instances that confirm your beliefs, your construction (or model)—and find them.

Empty-suit problem (or “expert problem”): Some professionals have no differential abilities from the rest of the population, but for some reason, and against their empirical records, are believed to be experts: clinical psychologists, academic economists, risk “experts,” statisticians, political analysts, financial “experts,” military analysts, CEOs, et cetera. They dress up their expertise in beautiful language, jargon, mathematics, and often wear expensive suits.